

CDN Incident Alert: 0084. TLP: CLEAR		Date
Title	MD Moldova elections targeted by Belarusian YouTube disinformation campaign	29/08/2025

Summary

- Between June 1-August 8, 2025, five Belarusian state-controlled media YouTube channels published at least 54 videos mentioning Moldova. The videos targeted Moldova's upcoming parliamentary elections and promoted Moldova's former pro-Russian president Igor Dodon.
- Key narratives included the delegitimization of democratic institutions, claims of EU interference, and the exploitation of Moldova's energy crisis.
- In total, the 54 videos garnered more than 3.8 million views. The majority of videos coincided with Dodon's visit to Minsk.
- The Belarusian state media narratives attempted to undermine Sandu's government, as well as trust towards democratic institutions and electoral processes. The government propaganda aimed to cultivate support for Igor Dodon's bloc and capitalize on existing socioeconomic vulnerabilities.
- Recommended actions include encouraging further transparency reporting from YouTube and further monitoring of coordinated cross-border FIMI activity.

Incident

Five Belarusian state media YouTube channels ([CTVBYvideo](#), [ont_by](#), [sbbytoday](#), [beltavideo](#), and [news.by btrc](#)) published 54 videos promoting narratives that sought to discredit Moldova's elections while supporting Igor Dodon. A spike in frequency occurred on July 12–13, when 20 videos were released, timed with Dodon's visit to Minsk and his meeting with Belarusian President Aleksandr Lukashenko. For example, one [video](#), titled "Lukashenko giving advice to Dodon," framed Moldova's independence as threatened by Western integration, portraying the EU as unreliable and exploitative, citing Ukraine's experience as evidence. The video positioned Belarus and Russia as natural partners, urging Moldovans to make a "wise choice" in the upcoming elections and resist unions with the West. Two videos ([here](#) and [here](#)) published by CTVBY promoted Dodon's opposition bloc, which alleged election fraud and manipulation by Sandu's government and accused the EU of interfering in electoral processes. Belarusian state media also [exploited](#) Moldova's economic challenges, discussing topics such as high energy costs, population decline, and economic stagnation. Another [video](#) published by NEWS.BY claimed that under Sandu, Moldova's population is declining rapidly. The video used fearmongering tactics, for example, "Sandu and her party, PAS, say they need another four years to complete what they started. If the beginning meant a loss of a quarter of a million Moldovans, what will the completion look like?" Five Belarusian state media YouTube channels collectively amplifying Moldova-related narratives demonstrate the strategic significance of the upcoming Moldovan elections. In total, the 54 videos garnered more than 3.8 million views.

Systemic Violation Assessment

This incident poses a risk, as the narratives promoted by Belarusian state media could erode public trust in Moldova's electoral process. By spreading false claims of election fraud and economic collapse, voter behavior could be impacted or distorted, weakening democratic institutions.

This incident constitutes the manipulation of information as the narratives center on claims of election fraud, economic collapse, and Moldova's alleged dependence on foreign powers.

Narrative

Meta-narrative: Moldova is under threat from Western influence.

Sub-narratives: Moldova's elections are rigged or fraudulent; The EU interferes in domestic and electoral processes; The EU and NATO exert colonial-style control over Moldova; Igor Dodon is the only leader endorsed by Belarus; The energy crisis is a result of European choices; Belarus and Russia offer stability.

Impact

Reach: The 54 videos mentioning Moldova garnered over 3.8 million views, 61, 900 likes, and 4, 900 comments

on YouTube.

Outcome: N/A

Key Objectives and Behaviours

Objective: [T0135: Undermine](#) – The videos spread narratives undermining democratic governance in Moldova and the West.

Objective: [T0136.005: Cultivate Support for Initiative](#) – The videos promote Igor Dodon and his political bloc opposing Sandu.

[T0003: Leverage Existing Narratives](#) – Well-known narratives about the economic and social consequences of Moldova aligning itself with the West were circulated.

[T0083: Integrate Target Audience Vulnerabilities into Narrative](#) – The claims linked energy and social issues to EU policies and Western alignment, while promoting Belarus and Russia as the solution.

[T0097.202: News Outlet Persona](#) - The channels used are Belarusian state-controlled news outlets.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Recommendations:

- Advocate for platform transparency reporting on FIMI from state-affiliated accounts;
- Engage Moldovan civil society in pre-bunking campaigns to counter specific sub-narratives;
- Monitor election-related disinformation campaigns from Belarusian and Russian sources in other countries.
- Publish articles in independent Belarusian media about Moldova's election campaign and tactics to undermine it;
- Foster joint publications between Belarusian and Moldovan independent media;
- Organize a civil society engagement on hybrid threats involving Belarusian and Moldovan NGOs.

Repo rt	Threat Actor	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	FIMI Assessment
NA	Belarus	https://factcheck.by/eng/news/moldova_fimi_campaign/	Mikhail Doroshevich, FactCheck.BY; Sopo Gelava, DFRLab	YouTube	High certainty